

4. In the acquisition of knowledge, can we only understand something to the extent that we understand its context? Discuss with reference to two areas of knowledge.

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When we talk about understanding something, we rarely mean simply memorizing information. Rather, understanding implies being able to explain why something happens, and how it works, moreover, being able to sort it into the existing frames of knowledge, and explain its significance. This raises the question of whether understanding something requires context. By context, we mean the background conditions, be it historical, cultural, theoretical or methodological, within the knowledge is produced and interpreted. The title suggests that context has boundaries and hence could be understood “fully”. However in reality, context is more complex and potentially infinite, containing different aspects. I will not treat context as something infinite or infinite, but rather as potential relevant conditions. Specifically, I will focus on how context influences our understanding of The Arts and Natural Science. In The Arts, our understanding of meaning consists of interpretations, which depend heavily on the historical and cultural context. While in contrast, Natural Science aims for universal claims of knowledge, for which you need the understanding of the methodological conditions, under which the claims hold true.

In the arts, understanding something often means being able to interpret its meaning. The interpretation of meaning is very dependent on our understanding of its historical and cultural context. I think that a work must be placed within the historical, social, and cultural background of the author, in order for the reader to understand the significance, which is a crucial part of understanding the work as a whole.

For example, in the novel *Tales of Hulan River*, written by Xiao Hong, the work becomes very shallow and loses significance if the reader is unaware of its historical and cultural context. Without knowing the context, the story appears simply to be about a tragedy around a child-bride abused by her mother-in-law. Although the reader may feel empathic, the deeper significance of the work is missed. On the other hand,

if a reader knows about the 1930 Chinese background of rural feudalism, superstition, strict gender roles and political instability, they immediately understand how the story is a critique of dehumanizing and oppressive traditions. Social critique is the purpose of the art as knowledge to be acquired, which may be missed without the contextual understanding. “Understanding”, in this scenario, goes beyond the plot itself, but also recognizing what the plot represents. This example shows how meaning in the arts only becomes visible when the work is placed within its cultural and historical context.

Context not only clarifies meaning and conveys authorial critique, but also helps shape our understanding of more authorial choices such as symbolic and structural features. For example Bertolt Brecht's *Life of Galileo* uses techniques of epic theatre, including directly addressing the audience to achieve a feeling of detached emotions. If one were not aware of Brecht's context and conventions of epic theatre, one might know the events but misunderstand the authorial intention such as deliberately distancing the audience to provoke reflection. Being actively aware of this uncommon authorial choice, juxtaposed with Brecht's history of exile and his critical perspective towards authoritarianism, the reader can gain more insight into Brecht's critical commentary on political responsibility and intellectual freedom. This example again highlights how context shapes the meaning that common audiences are able to see.

One could argue that only literature forms of the arts are in need of context, while artworks don't. However, actually even this type of apparently “context-free” art form depends on context for a deeper understanding. For example, without understanding Surrealism and its challenge to reality and representation, Magritte's artwork “The Treachery of Images” may appear confusing. As the subtitle and the visual are self-contradictory. However, knowing the context, it turns out to be a philosophical statement about the instability of language and perception. This illustrates how artworks intended to resist conventional interpretation largely relies on the audience knowing the context to achieve its significance and point of critique.

However, there are also areas within The Arts that could be understood without knowing the context, which is, when trying to understand emotions. Often in music, we associate minor chords with a feeling of sadness, even without knowing the composer's background or historical period. Emotions are able to cross the boundary of cultural or historical limits. This specifically suggests that some form of understanding does not require context. This highlights how there are two kinds of understanding in the arts: emotional understanding, which could appear without context, and interpretative understanding, which heavily relies on content. If understanding refers to grasping the meaning and significance, then context is essential in the arts. On the other hand, this understanding only refers to emotional reactions of the recipient, then context is less important. This suggests that context shapes the depth and types of understanding that could possibly be achieved, rather than determining whether understanding is possible at all.

The Area of knowledge of natural science also creates and communicates knowledge, however unlike the art, it aims to develop universal language that holds across time, place and culture. Although scientific knowledge often appears independent of context, the process through which the knowledge is created or discovered is shaped by methodological context, which includes tools, experiment conditions and theoretical assumptions.

Firstly, many laws in science appear to be context-free and universally true. For example, the structure of gold does not change or depend on whether it is studied in Japan or in Brazil, hence free of cultural context. Similarly, the conservation of energy applies not only in physics, but also in chemistry and biology. A student can apply Newton's laws without Newton's biography or his historical background of their discovery in order to understand or apply Newton's laws of gravity. This suggests that the scientific knowledge, content being investigated and communicated in science, is independent of cultural or historical context.

Though free of historical and cultural context, many scientific understandings still require the audience to grasp its methodological context. For example, the simple and daily fact of “Water boils at 100 Celcius” actually only holds at the standard atmospheric pressure. This means that if your altitude changes, for example if you are on top of the Himalayas, the water actually boils at different temperatures. Hence, without understanding this specific methodological context, in physics also commonly referred to as a limitation, the fact itself is incomplete or even misleading. Thus, understanding in the Natural Sciences depends not on cultural context, but on recognising the methodological assumptions that determine when a claim is valid.

Moreover, assumptions and commonly shared knowledge are also part of science, and to understand science does not mean to simply memorise a formula, but about being able to explain models, symbols and methods behind them. For example, the equation $F=mg$, actually requires the audience to know what the variable represents and how force and acceleration are measured. In addition, this equation actually is only true on earth, with the gravitational constant of $g = 9.81$. Hence, this form of understanding actually depends on the extent the audience understands its methodological context, including commonly accepted units and the procedure of experiments. Without this, scientific knowledge can lose its meaning, even if the underlying truth remains the same.

A counterclaim is that one may argue that relying on evidence, controlled experiment and peer review makes science less dependent on external context. Indeed, the universal aim is to make science free of subjectivity and not bounded by context, but true across time and space. Hence, this view is totally valid, and it highlights the central pursuit of science. Natural science, by increasing its methodological context, can reduce the cultural context. Hence, the need for context does not disappear, but changes the form, allowing the process of understanding to be easier and more precise.

Overall, comparing the two different Areas of Knowledge shows the varied perspective of the title, and how it cannot be answered uniformly. While the arts heavily relies on the meaning-context, which determines the significance of a work and interpreting its underlying message, natural science relies on the recipient to understand the methodological context, which shapes how knowledge is created, under which condition the experiment is done and when the claim actually holds true. Scientific knowledge can appear more context-free, simply because methodological context can be more standardised and hence understood more easily and comprehensively. In both areas, understanding involves being able to place the knowledge into appropriate context. Only, the context involved is different. This shows that context does not absolutely define our limit of understanding, but rather, it influences the kind of understanding we would like to achieve. This shows that we cannot entirely separate understanding from context. The broader implication of this discussion is that the process of understanding is a contextual process, as context shapes both interpretation and explanation. Maybe, the ideal form of knowledge could be understood context-free, yet humanity has not reached that point. Another question that emerges is whether expanding our knowledge of context actually always improves understanding, or whether there are certain cases where additional context obscures rather than clarifies knowledge.